> This, I said, could not be undertaken by the United States if we were to maintain our moral position at home and around the globe. Our struggle against Communism throughout the world was far more than physical survival – it had as its essence, our heritage and our ideals, and these we must not destroy.[45]

According to RFK, 'We spent more time on this moral question during the first five days than on any other single matter.'[46] Scrutiny of the records of the ExComm meetings demonstrate that this statement is not true. As Sheldon Stern has chronicled, the Presidential Recordings 'fundamentally and irrefutably contradict many of RFK's most important recollections and conclusions.'[47] The claim that he opposed the use of force is the most significant of these. At one point in the discussion, Robert Kennedy scribbled a note: 'I know now how Tojo felt when he was planning Pearl Harbor.' This 'wry' comment (according to Arthur Schlesinger) was frequently invoked as evidence of RFK's critical view of a surprise attack. It is now clear that the Attorney-General was, for several days, the leading advocate of military action, so his scribbled note might be seen as literal rather than sardonic.

Robert Kennedy came to support the blockade and played an active role in promoting a secret trade on the missiles in Turkey. And as he noted, many members of ExComm changed their minds as the discussion extended over nearly two weeks. Some senior officials were consistent. The Joint Chiefs were adamant on the need to remove not only the missiles but Castro as well. And they remained opposed to launching an attack aimed only at the missiles themselves. Their commitment to armed conflict was resolute. Maxwell Taylor had a more nuanced view. He was initially wary of invasion and that 'deep mud' in Cuba, though the identification of IRBM bases by 18 October, changed his mind. When Khrushchev announced on 28 October that the MRBMs would be removed, the Joint Chiefs argued that without 'irrefutable evidence' that they were being dismantled, the United States should proceed with air strikes.[48] Maxwell Taylor, who had otherwise supported an invasion, distanced himself from this recommendation.